

Countable and uncountable 1

A A noun can be *countable* or *uncountable*:

Countable

- ☐ I eat **a banana** every day.
- ☐ I like **bananas**.



Banana is a *countable* noun.

A countable noun can be singular (**banana**) or plural (**bananas**).

We can use numbers with countable nouns. So we can say **one banana, two bananas** etc.

Examples of nouns usually countable:

- ☐ Kate was singing **a song**.
- ☐ There's **a nice beach** near here.
- ☐ Do you have **a ten-pound note**?
- ☐ It wasn't your fault. It was **an accident**.
- ☐ There are no **batteries** in the radio.
- ☐ We don't have enough **cups**.

Uncountable

- ☐ I eat **rice** every day.
- ☐ I like **rice**.



Rice is an *uncountable* noun.

An uncountable noun has only one form (**rice**). There is no plural.

We cannot use numbers with uncountable nouns. We cannot say 'one rice', 'two rices' etc.

Examples of nouns usually uncountable:

- ☐ Kate was listening to **music**.
- ☐ There's **sand** in my shoes.
- ☐ Do you have any **money**?
- ☐ It wasn't your fault. It was bad **luck**.
- ☐ There is no **electricity** in this house.
- ☐ We don't have enough **water**.

B

You can use **a/an** with singular countable nouns:

a beach a student an umbrella

You cannot use singular countable nouns alone (without **a/the/my** etc.):

- ☐ Do you want **a banana**?
(*not* want banana)
- ☐ There's been **an accident**.
(*not* There's been accident)

You can use *plural* countable nouns alone:

- ☐ I like **bananas**. (= bananas in general)
- ☐ **Accidents** can be prevented.

We do not use **a/an** with uncountable nouns. We do not say 'a sand', 'a music', 'a rice'.

But you can often use **a ... of**. For example:
a bowl / a packet / a grain of rice

You can use uncountable nouns alone (without **the/my/some** etc.):

- ☐ I eat **rice** every day.
- ☐ There's **blood** on your shirt.
- ☐ Can you hear **music**?

C

You can use **some** and **any** with plural countable nouns:

- ☐ We sang **some songs**.
- ☐ Did you buy **any apples**?

We use **many** and **few** with plural countable nouns:

- ☐ We didn't take **many pictures**.
- ☐ I have a **few things** to do.

You can use **some** and **any** with uncountable nouns:

- ☐ We listened to **some music**.
- ☐ Did you buy **any apple juice**?

We use **much** and **little** with uncountable nouns:

- ☐ We didn't do **much shopping**.
- ☐ I have a **little work** to do.

Exercises

69.1 Some of these sentences need **a/an**. Correct the sentences where necessary.

- 1 Joe goes everywhere by bike. He doesn't have a car.
- 2 Helen was listening to music when I arrived. OK
- 3 We went to very nice restaurant last weekend.
- 4 I brush my teeth with toothpaste.
- 5 I use toothbrush to brush my teeth.
- 6 Can you tell me if there's bank near here?
- 7 My brother works for insurance company.
- 8 I don't like violence.
- 9 When we were in Rome, we stayed in big hotel.
- 10 If you have problem, I'll try and help you.
- 11 I like your suggestion. It's interesting idea.
- 12 Can you smell paint?
- 13 I like volleyball. It's good game.
- 14 Lisa doesn't usually wear jewellery.
- 15 Jane was wearing beautiful necklace.
- 16 Does this city have airport?

69.2 Complete the sentences using the following words. Use **a/an** where necessary.

accident ice	biscuit interview	blood key	coat moment	decision music	electricity question
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- 1 The road is closed. There's been an accident
- 2 Listen! Can you hear music ?
- 3 I couldn't get into the house. I didn't have
- 4 It's very warm today. Why are you wearing ?
- 5 Would you like in your drink?
- 6 Are you hungry? Have !
- 7 Our lives would be very difficult without
- 8 Excuse me, can I ask you ?
- 9 I'm not ready yet. Can you wait , please?
- 10 The heart pumps through the body.
- 11 We can't delay much longer. We have to make soon.
- 12 I had for a job yesterday. It went quite well.

69.3 Complete the sentences using the following words:

air patience	day people	friend picture	joke queue	language space	meat umbrella
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Sometimes the word needs to be plural (**-s**), and sometimes you need to use **a/an**.

- 1 I had a camera with me, but I didn't take any pictures
- 2 There are seven in a week.
- 3 A vegetarian is a person who doesn't eat
- 4 Outside the cinema there was of people waiting to see the film.
- 5 I'm not good at telling
- 6 Last night I went out with some of mine.
- 7 There were very few in town today. The streets were almost empty.
- 8 I'm going out for a walk. I need some fresh
- 9 Paul always wants things quickly. He doesn't have much
- 10 I think it's going to rain. Do you have I could borrow?
- 11 How many can you speak?
- 12 Our flat is very small. We don't have much

Countable and uncountable 2

A

Many nouns are sometimes countable, and sometimes uncountable. Usually there is a difference in meaning. Compare:

Countable

- ☐ Did you hear **a noise** just now?
(= a specific noise)
- ☐ I bought **a paper** to read.
(= a newspaper)
- ☐ There's **a hair** in my soup!
(= one single hair)
- ☐ This is **a nice room**.
(= a room in a house)
- ☐ I had some interesting **experiences**
while I was travelling.
(= things that happened to me)
- ☐ Enjoy your trip. Have **a great time**!

Uncountable

- ☐ I can't work here. There's too much **noise**. (= noise in general)
- ☐ I need **some paper** to write on.
(= material for writing on)
- ☐ You've got very long **hair**. (*not* hairs)
(= all the hair on your head)
- ☐ You can't sit here. There isn't **room**.
(= space)
- ☐ I was offered the job because I had a lot of **experience**. (*not* experiences)
(= experience of that type of job)
- ☐ I can't wait. I don't have **time**.

Coffee/tea/juice/beer etc. (drinks) are normally uncountable:

- ☐ I don't like **coffee** very much.

But you can say **a coffee** (= a cup of coffee), **two coffees** (= two cups) etc. :

- ☐ **Two coffees** and **an orange juice**, please.

B

These nouns are usually uncountable:

accommodation	behaviour	damage	luck	permission	traffic
advice	bread	furniture	luggage	progress	weather
baggage	chaos	information	news	scenery	work

We do not normally use **a/an** with these nouns:

- ☐ I'm going to buy **some bread**. *or* ... **a loaf of bread**. (*not* a bread)
- ☐ Enjoy your holiday! I hope you have good **weather**. (*not* a good weather)

These nouns are not usually plural (so we do not say 'breads', 'furnitures' etc.):

- ☐ Where are you going to put all your **furniture**? (*not* furnitures)
- ☐ Let me know if you need more **information**. (*not* informations)

News is uncountable, not plural:

- ☐ The **news was** unexpected. (*not* The news were)

Travel (*noun*) means 'travelling in general' (uncountable). We do not say 'a travel' to mean **a trip** or **a journey**:

- ☐ They spend a lot of money on **travel**.
- ☐ We had a very good **trip/journey**. (*not* a good travel)

Compare these countable and uncountable nouns:

Countable

- ☐ I'm looking for **a job**.
- ☐ What **a beautiful view**!
- ☐ It's **a nice day** today.
- ☐ We had a lot of **bags**.
- ☐ **These chairs** are mine.
- ☐ That's **a good suggestion**.
- ☐ There were a lot of **cars**.

Uncountable

- ☐ I'm looking for **work**. (*not* a work)
- ☐ What beautiful **scenery**!
- ☐ It's nice **weather** today.
- ☐ We had a lot of **baggage/luggage**.
- ☐ **This furniture** is mine.
- ☐ That's good **advice**.
- ☐ There **was** a lot of **traffic**.

Exercises

70.1 Which is correct?

- 1 a The engine is making strange noise / a strange noise. What is it? (a strange noise is correct)
- b We live near a busy road so there's a lot of noise / there are a lot of noises.
- 2 a Light / A light comes from the sun.
- b I thought there was somebody in the house because there was light / a light on inside.
- 3 a I was in a hurry this morning. I didn't have time / a time for breakfast.
- b We really enjoyed our holiday. We had great time / a great time.
- 4 a Can I have glass of water / a glass of water, please?
- b Be careful. The window has been broken and there's broken glass / a broken glass on the floor.
- 5 a We stayed at a hotel. We had very nice room / a very nice room.
- b We have a big garage. There's room / a room for two cars.

70.2 Which is correct?

- 1 Did you have nice weather / a nice weather when you were away? (nice weather is correct)
- 2 We were very unfortunate. We had bad luck / a bad luck.
- 3 Our travel / journey from Paris to Moscow by train was very tiring.
- 4 When the fire alarm rang, there was complete chaos / a complete chaos.
- 5 Bad news don't / doesn't make people happy.
- 6 There's some lovely scenery / a lovely scenery in this part of the country.
- 7 I like my job, but it's very hard work / a very hard work.
- 8 I want to print some documents, but the printer is out of paper / papers.
- 9 The trip took a long time. There was heavy traffic / a heavy traffic.
- 10 Your hair is / Your hairs are too long. You should have it / them cut.

70.3 Complete the sentences using the following words. Use the plural (-s) where necessary.

advice	chair	damage	experience	experience
furniture	hair	luggage	permission	progress

- 1 We didn't have much luggage – just two small bags.
- 2 We have no _____, not even a bed or a table.
- 3 There is room for everybody to sit down. There are plenty of _____.
- 4 Who is that woman with short _____? Do you know her?
- 5 Carla's English is better than it was. She's made good _____.
- 6 If you want to take pictures here, you need to ask for _____.
- 7 I didn't know what I should do, so I asked Chris for _____.
- 8 I don't think Dan should get the job. He doesn't have enough _____.
- 9 Kate has done many interesting things. She could write a book about her _____.
- 10 The _____ caused by the storm will cost a lot to repair.

70.4 What do you say in these situations? Use the word in brackets in your sentence.

- 1 Your friends have just arrived at the station. You can't see any cases or bags. You ask:
(luggage) Do you have any luggage _____?
- 2 You go to a tourist office. You want to know about places to visit in the town.
(information) I'd like _____.
- 3 You are a student. You want your teacher to advise you about which courses to do. You say:
(advice) Can you give _____?
- 4 You applied for a job and you've just heard that you were successful. You call Tom and say:
(good news) Hi, Tom. I _____ I got the job!
- 5 You are at the top of a mountain. You can see a very long way. It's beautiful. You say:
(view) It _____, isn't it?
- 6 You look out of the window. The weather is horrible: cold, wet and windy. You say:
(weather) What _____!

Countable nouns with **a/an** and **some**

A Countable nouns can be *singular* or *plural*:

a dog	a child	the evening	this party	an umbrella
dogs	some children	the evenings	these parties	two umbrellas

Before singular countable nouns you can use **a/an**:

- ☐ Bye! Have **a** nice **evening**.
- ☐ Do you need **an** **umbrella**?

You cannot use singular countable nouns alone (without **a/the/my** etc.):

- ☐ She never wears **a** **hat**. (*not* wears hat)
- ☐ Be careful of **the** **dog**.
- ☐ What **a** beautiful **day**!
- ☐ Did you hurt **your** **leg**?

B We use **a/an** ... to say what kind of thing something is, or what kind of person somebody is:

- ☐ That's a **nice** **table**.

In the plural we use the noun alone (*not* some ...):

- ☐ Those are **nice** **chairs**. (*not* some nice chairs)

Compare singular and plural:

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ A dog is an animal . | ☐ Dogs are animals . |
| ☐ I'm an optimist . | ☐ We're optimists . |
| ☐ My father is a doctor . | ☐ My parents are both doctors . |
| ☐ Jane is a really nice person . | ☐ Jane and Ben are really nice people . |
| ☐ What a lovely dress ! | ☐ What awful shoes ! |

We say that somebody has **a long nose** / **a nice face** / **blue eyes** / **long fingers** etc. :

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Jack has a long nose .
(<i>not</i> the long nose) | ☐ Jack has blue eyes .
(<i>not</i> the blue eyes) |
|---|---|

We use **a/an** when we say what somebody's job is:

- ☐ Sandra is **a** **nurse**. (*not* Sandra is nurse)
- ☐ Would you like to be **an** **English teacher**?

C You can use **some** with plural countable nouns. We use **some** in two ways.

(1) **some** = a number (of) / a few (of) / a pair (of):

- ☐ I've seen **some** good **movies** recently. (*not* I've seen good movies)
- ☐ **Some** **friends** of mine are coming to stay at the weekend.
- ☐ I need **some** new **sunglasses**. (= a new pair of sunglasses)

Often you can say the same thing with or without **some**. For example:

- ☐ I need (**some**) new **clothes**.
- ☐ The room was empty apart from a table and (**some**) **chairs**.

Do not use **some** when you are talking about things in general (see Unit 75):

- ☐ I love **bananas**. (*not* some bananas)
- ☐ My aunt is a writer. She writes **books**. (*not* some books)

(2) **some** = some but not all:

- ☐ **Some** **children** learn very quickly. (but not all children)
- ☐ Tomorrow there will be rain in **some** **places**, but most of the country will be dry.

Exercises

71.1 What are these things? Choose from the box and write a sentence.

- 1 an eagle It's a bird.
- 2 a pigeon, a duck and a penguin They're birds.
- 3 carrots and onions
- 4 a tulip
- 5 Earth, Mars and Jupiter
- 6 chess
- 7 a hammer, a saw and a screwdriver
- 8 the Nile, the Rhine and the Mekong
- 9 a mosquito
- 10 Hindi, Arabic and Swahili

bird(s)
flower(s)
game(s)
insect(s)
language(s)
planet(s)
river(s)
tool(s)
vegetable(s)

71.2 Read about what these people do. What are their jobs? Choose from:

chef interpreter journalist ~~nurse~~ plumber surgeon tour guide waiter

- 1 Sarah looks after patients in hospital. She's a nurse.
- 2 Gary works in a restaurant. He brings the food to the tables. He
- 3 Jane writes articles for a newspaper.
- 4 Kevin works in a hospital. He operates on people.
- 5 Jonathan cooks in a restaurant.
- 6 Dave installs and repairs water pipes.
- 7 Anna shows visitors round her city and tells them about it.
- 8 Lisa translates what people are saying from one language into another, so that they can understand each other.

71.3 Which is right?

- 1 Most of my friends are students / ~~some students~~. (students is correct)
- 2 Are you careful driver / a careful driver?
- 3 I went to the library and borrowed books / some books.
- 4 Mark works in a bookshop. He sells books / some books.
- 5 I've been walking for hours. I've got sore feet / some sore feet.
- 6 I don't feel very well. I've got sore throat / a sore throat.
- 7 What lovely present / a lovely present! Thank you very much.
- 8 I met students / some students in a cafe yesterday. They were from China.
- 9 It might rain. Don't go out without umbrella / without an umbrella.
- 10 People / Some people learn languages more easily than others.

71.4 Put in a/an or some where necessary. If no word is necessary, leave the space empty.

- 1 I've seen some good movies recently.
- 2 Are you feeling all right? Do you have a headache?
- 3 I know lots of people. Most of them are students.
- 4 When I was child, I used to be very shy.
- 5 birds, for example the penguin, cannot fly.
- 6 Would you like to be actor?
- 7 Questions, questions, questions! You're always asking questions!
- 8 I didn't expect to see you. What surprise!
- 9 Do you like staying in hotels?
- 10 Tomorrow is a holiday. shops will be open, but most of them will be closed.
- 11 Those are nice shoes. Where did you get them?
- 12 You need visa to visit countries, but not all of them.
- 13 Kate is teacher. Her parents were teachers too.
- 14 I don't believe him. He's liar. He's always telling lies.

A Study this example:

I had **a sandwich** and **an apple** for lunch.

The sandwich wasn't very good, but **the apple** was nice.



JOE

Joe says '**a** sandwich', '**an** apple' because this is the first time he talks about them.

Joe now says '**the** sandwich', '**the** apple' because we know which sandwich and which apple he means – **the** sandwich and **the** apple he had for lunch.

Compare **a** and **the** in these examples:

- ☐ **A man** and **a woman** were sitting opposite me. **The man** was American, but I think **the woman** was British.
- ☐ When we were on holiday, we stayed at **a hotel**. Sometimes we ate at **the hotel** and sometimes we went to **a restaurant**.

B We use **the** when we are thinking of a specific thing. Compare **a/an** and **the**:

- ☐ Tim sat down on **a chair**. (maybe one of many chairs in the room)
- Tim sat down on **the chair nearest the door**. (a specific chair)
- ☐ Do you have **a car**? (not a specific car)
- I cleaned **the car** yesterday. (= my car)

We use **a/an** when we say what kind of thing or person we mean. Compare:

- ☐ We stayed at **a very cheap hotel**. (a type of hotel)
- The hotel where we stayed** was very cheap. (a specific hotel)

C We use **the** when it is clear which thing or person we mean. For example, in a room we talk about **the light / the floor / the ceiling / the door / the carpet** etc. :

- ☐ Can you turn off **the light**, please? (= the light in this room)
- ☐ I took a taxi to **the station**. (= the station in that town)
- ☐ (*in a shop*) I'd like to speak to **the manager**, please. (= the manager of this shop)

We also say '(go to) **the bank / the post office**':

- ☐ I have to go to **the bank** and then I'm going to **the post office**.
(The speaker is usually thinking of a specific bank or post office.)

and '(go to) **the doctor / the dentist**':

- ☐ Clare isn't well. She's gone to **the doctor**.
- ☐ I don't like going to **the dentist**.

Compare **the** and **a**:

- ☐ I have to go to **the bank** today.
Is there **a bank** near here?
- ☐ I don't like going to **the dentist**.
My sister is **a dentist**.

D We say 'once **a week** / three times **a day** / £1.50 **a kilo**' etc. :

- ☐ I go to the cinema about once **a month**.
- ☐ 'How much are those potatoes?' '£1.50 **a kilo**.'
- ☐ Helen works eight hours **a day**, six days **a week**.

Exercises

72.1 Put in a/an or the.

- 1 This morning I bought a book and magazine. book is in my bag, but I can't remember where I put magazine.
- 2 I saw accident this morning. car crashed into tree. driver of car wasn't hurt, but car was badly damaged.
- 3 There are two cars parked outside: blue one and grey one. blue one belongs to my neighbours. I don't know who owner of grey one is.
- 4 My friends live in old house in small village. There is beautiful garden behind house. I would like to have garden like that.

72.2 Put in a/an or the.

- 1 a This house is very nice. Does it have garden?
b It's a beautiful day. Let's sit in garden.
c I like living in this house, but it's a shame that garden is so small.
- 2 a Can you recommend good restaurant?
b We had dinner in very nice restaurant.
c We had dinner in best restaurant in town.
- 3 a What's name of that man we met yesterday?
b We stayed at a very nice hotel – I can't remember name now.
c My neighbour has French name, but in fact she's English, not French.
- 4 a Did Paula get job she applied for?
b It's not easy to get job at the moment.
c Do you enjoy your work? Is it interesting job?
- 5 a 'Are you going away next week?' 'No, week after next.'
b I'm going away for week in September.
c Gary has a part-time job. He works three mornings week.

72.3 Put in a/an or the where necessary.

- 1 Would you like an apple?
- 2 How often do you go to dentist?
- 3 Can you close door, please?
- 4 I have problem. I need your help.
- 5 How far is it from here to station?
- 6 I'm going to post office. I won't be long.
- 7 Paul plays tennis. He's very good player.
- 8 There isn't airport near where I live.
- 9 Nearest airport is 70 miles away.
- 10 There were no chairs, so we sat on floor.
- 11 Have you finished with book I lent you?
- 12 Chris has just got job in bank in Zurich.
- 13 We live in small apartment in city centre.
- 14 There's shop at end of street I live in.

Would you like an apple?

72.4 Answer these questions. Where possible, use once a week / three times a day etc.

- 1 How often do you go to the cinema? Three or four times a year.
- 2 How often do you go to the dentist?
- 3 How often do you go away on holiday?
- 4 How long do you usually sleep?
- 5 How often do you go out in the evening?
- 6 How many hours of TV do you watch (on average)?
- 7 What's the usual speed limit in towns in your country?

A

We use **the** when there is only one of something:

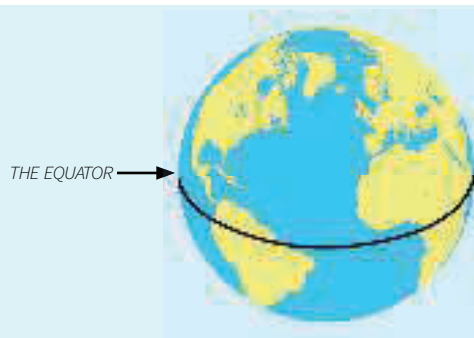
- ☐ Have you ever crossed **the equator**?
(there is only one equator)
- ☐ Our apartment is on **the tenth floor**.
- ☐ Buenos Aires is **the capital of Argentina**.
- ☐ I'm going away at **the end of this month**.

We use **the** + *superlative* (**best**, **oldest** etc.):

- ☐ What's **the longest river in Europe**?

Compare **the** and **a/an** (see also Units 71–72):

- ☐ **The sun** is **a star**. (= one of many stars)
- ☐ **The hotel** where we stayed was **a very old hotel**.
- ☐ We live in **an apartment** on **the tenth floor**.
- ☐ What's **the best way** to learn **a language**?



B

We say '**the same**':

- ☐ Your sweater is **the same** colour as mine. (*not* is same colour)
- ☐ 'Are these keys **the same**?' 'No, they're different.'

C

We say: **the world** **the universe** **the sun** **the moon** **the earth**
the sky **the sea** **the ground** **the country** (= not a town)

- ☐ I love to look at the stars in **the sky**. (*not* in sky)
- ☐ Do you live in a town or in **the country**?
- ☐ **The earth** goes round **the sun**, and **the moon** goes round **the earth**.

We also use **Earth** (without **the**) when we think of it as a planet in space (like **Mars**, **Jupiter** etc.).

- ☐ Which is the planet nearest **Earth**?

We say **space** (without **the**) when we mean 'space in the universe'. Compare:

- ☐ There are millions of stars **in space**. (*not* in the space)
- ☐ I tried to park my car, but **the space** was too small.

D

We say:

(go to) **the cinema**, **the theatre**

- ☐ I go to **the cinema** a lot, but I haven't been to **the theatre** for ages.

TV / television (without **the**), but **the radio**

- ☐ I watch **TV** a lot, but I don't listen to **the radio** much.

but Can you turn off **the television**, please? (**the** television = the TV set)

the internet

- ☐ **The internet** has changed the way we live.

E

We usually say **breakfast/lunch/dinner** (without **the**):

- ☐ What did you have for **breakfast**?
- ☐ We had **lunch** in a very nice restaurant.

But we say '**a big** lunch', '**a wonderful** dinner', '**an early** breakfast' etc.

- ☐ We had **a very nice lunch**. (*not* We had very nice lunch)

F

We say: **size 43**, **platform 5** etc. (without **the**)

- ☐ Our train leaves from **platform 5**. (*not* the platform 5)
- ☐ Do you have these shoes in **size 43**? (*not* the size 43)

In the same way, we say: **room 126**, **page 29**, **vitamin A**, **section B** etc.

Exercises

73.1 Put in *the* or *a* where necessary. If no word is necessary, leave the space empty.

- 1 A: Our apartment is on the tenth floor.
B: Is it? I hope there's lift.
- 2 A: Did you have nice holiday?
B: Yes, it was best holiday I've ever had.
- 3 A: Where's nearest shop?
B: There's one at end of this street.
- 4 A: It's lovely day, isn't it?
B: Yes, there isn't cloud in sky.
- 5 A: We spent all our money because we stayed at most expensive hotel in town.
B: Why didn't you stay at cheaper hotel?
- 6 A: Would you like to travel in space?
B: Yes, I'd love to go to moon.
- 7 A: What did you think of movie last night?
B: It was OK, but I thought ending was a bit strange.
- 8 A: What's Jupiter? Is it star?
B: No, it's planet. It's largest planet in solar system.

73.2 Which is right? (For *the*, see also Unit 72.)

- 1 I haven't been to cinema / the cinema for ages. (*the cinema is correct*)
- 2 Sarah spends most of her free time watching TV / the TV.
- 3 Do you ever listen to radio / the radio?
- 4 Television / The television was on, but nobody was watching it.
- 5 Have you had dinner / the dinner yet?
- 6 It's confusing when two people have same name / the same name.
- 7 What do you want for breakfast / for the breakfast?
- 8 Fruit is an important source of vitamin C / the vitamin C.
- 9 This computer is not connected to internet / the internet.
- 10 I lay down on ground / the ground and looked up at sky / the sky.
- 11 Next train / The next train to London leaves from platform 3 / the platform 3.

73.3 Put in *the* or *a* where necessary. (For *a* and *the* see also Units 71–72.)

- 1 Sun is star. The sun is a star.
- 2 I'm fed up with doing same thing every day.
- 3 Room 25 is on second floor.
- 4 It was very hot day. It was hottest day of year.
- 5 We had lunch in nice restaurant by sea.
- 6 What's on at cinema this week?
- 7 I had big breakfast this morning.
- 8 You'll find information you need at top of page 15.

73.4 Complete the sentences. Choose from the box and use *the* where necessary.

breakfast cinema gate Gate 24 ~~lunch~~ question question 3 sea

- 1 I'm hungry. It's time for lunch.
- 2 There was no wind, so was very calm.
- 3 Most of the questions in the test were OK, but I couldn't answer
- 4 'I'm going to tonight.' 'Are you? What are you going to see?'
- 5 I'm sorry, but could you repeat, please?
- 6 I didn't have this morning because I was in a hurry.
- 7 (*airport announcement*) Flight AB123 to Rome is now boarding at
- 8 I forgot to shut Can you shut it for me?

the 2 (school / the school etc.)

A Compare **school** and **the school**:

Ellie is ten years old. Every day she goes **to school**. She's **at school** now. **School** starts at 9 and finishes at 3.

We say a child goes **to school** or is **at school** (as a student). We are not thinking of a specific school. We are thinking of **school** as a *general* idea – children learning in a classroom.



Today Ellie's mother wants to speak to her daughter's teacher. So she has gone to **the school** to see her. She's at **the school** now.

Ellie's mother is not a student. She is not 'at school', she doesn't 'go to school'. If she wants to see Ellie's teacher, she goes to **the school** (= Ellie's school, a specific building).

B We use **prison** (or **jail**), **hospital**, **university**, **college** and **church** in a similar way. We do not use **the** when we are thinking of the general idea of these places and what they are used for. Compare:

- ☐ When I leave school, I plan to go **to university** / go **to college**. (as a student)
- ☐ Joe had an accident last week. He was taken **to hospital**. He's still **in hospital** now. (as a patient)
- ☐ Ken's brother is **in prison** for robbery. (He is a prisoner. We are not thinking of a specific prison.)
- ☐ Sarah's father goes **to church** every Sunday. (for a religious service)

- ☐ I went to **the university** to meet Professor Thomas. (as a visitor, not as a student)
- ☐ Jane has gone to **the hospital** to visit Joe. She's **at the hospital** now. (as a visitor, not as a patient)
- ☐ Ken went to **the prison** to visit his brother. (He went as a visitor, not as a prisoner.)
- ☐ Some workmen went to **the church** to repair the roof. (a specific building)

With most other places, you need **the**. For example, **the station**, **the cinema** (see Units 72C and 73D).

C We say **go to bed** / **be in bed** etc. (*not* the bed):

- ☐ I'm going **to bed** now. Goodnight.
- ☐ Do you ever have breakfast **in bed**?

but

- ☐ I sat down on **the bed**. (a specific piece of furniture)

go to work / **be at work** / **start work** / **finish work** etc. (*not* the work):

- ☐ Chris didn't go **to work** yesterday.
- ☐ What time do you usually finish **work**?

go home / **come home** / **arrive home** / **get home** / **be (at) home** / do something **at home** etc. :

- ☐ It's late. Let's **go home**.
- ☐ I don't go out to work. I work **at home**.

Exercises

74.1 Complete the sentences with **school** or **the school**.

- Why aren't your children at school today? Are they ill?
- When he was younger, Ben hated, but he enjoys it now.
- There were some parents waiting outside to meet their children.
- What time does start in the morning?
- How do your children get to and from? Do you take them?
- What was the name of you attended?
- What does Emily want to do when she leaves?
- My children walk to isn't very far.

74.2 Which is right?

- Where is university / the university? Is it near here? (the university is correct)
 - Neil left school and got a job. He didn't want to go to university / the university.
 - In your country, what proportion of the population study at university / the university?
 - This is a small town, but university / the university is the biggest in the country.
- My brother has always been healthy. He's never been in hospital / the hospital.
 - When my friend was ill, I went to hospital / the hospital to see her.
 - When I was visiting my friend, I met Lisa, who is a nurse at hospital / the hospital.
 - I saw an accident. A woman was injured and was taken to hospital / the hospital.
- Why is she in prison / the prison? What crime did she commit?
 - There was a fire at prison / the prison. Firefighters were called to put it out.
 - Do you think too many people are sent to prison / the prison?
- John's mother is a regular churchgoer. She goes to church / the church every Sunday.
 - John himself doesn't go to church / the church.
 - The village is very nice. You should visit church / the church. It's interesting.

74.3 Complete the sentences. Choose from the box.

- How did you get home after the party?
- How do you usually go in the morning? By bus?
- Sam likes to go to early and get up early.
- I don't have my phone. I left it
- 'Have you seen my keys?' 'Yes, they're on
- Shall we meet tomorrow evening?
- I like to read before going to sleep.
- It was a long tiring journey. We arrived very late.
- Tom usually finishes at five o'clock.
- It's nice to travel around, but there's no place

bed
the bed
in bed
~~home~~
home
at home
like home
work
to work
after work

74.4 Complete the sentences. Choose **at/in/to** + **hospital, school** etc.

bed home ~~hospital~~ hospital prison school university work

- Kate's mother has to have an operation. She'll be in hospital for a few days.
- In your country, from what age do children have to go?
- Mark didn't go out last night. He stayed
- There is a lot of traffic in the morning when people are going
- When Sophie leaves school, she wants to study psychology
- Ben never gets up before 9 o'clock. It's 8.30 now, so he is still
- The accident wasn't serious. Nobody had to go
- If people commit crimes, they may end up

the 3 (children / the children)

A

When we are talking about things or people in general, we do *not* use **the**:

- ☐ I'm afraid of **dogs**. (*not* the dogs)
(**dogs** = dogs in general, not a specific group of dogs)
- ☐ **Doctors** are usually paid more than **teachers**.
- ☐ Do you know anybody who collects **stamps**?
- ☐ **Life** has changed a lot in the last thirty years.
- ☐ Do you like **classical music** / **Chinese food** / **fast cars**?
- ☐ My favourite sport is **football/skiing/athletics**.
- ☐ My favourite subject at school was **history/physics/English**.



We say '**most** people / **most** shops / **most** big cities' etc. (*not* the most ...):

- ☐ **Most shops** accept credit cards. (*not* The most shops)

B

We use **the** when we mean specific things or people.

Compare:

*In general (without **the**)*

- ☐ **Children** learn from playing.
(= children in general)
- ☐ I couldn't live without **music**.
- ☐ All **cars** have wheels.
- ☐ **Sugar** isn't very good for you.
- ☐ **English people** drink a lot of tea.
(= English people in general)

*Specific people or things (with **the**)*

- ☐ We took **the children** to the zoo.
(= a specific group, perhaps the speaker's children)
- ☐ The film wasn't very good, but I liked **the music**. (= the music in the film)
- ☐ All **the cars in this car park** belong to people who work here.
- ☐ Can you pass **the sugar**, please?
(= the sugar on the table)
- ☐ **The English people I know** drink a lot of tea. (= only the English people I know, not English people in general)

C

The difference between 'something in general' and 'something specific' is not always very clear.

Compare:

*In general (without **the**)*

- ☐ I like working with **people**.
(= people in general)
- ☐ I like working with **people who say what they think**.
(not all people, but 'people who say what they think' is still a general idea)
- ☐ Do you like **coffee**?
(= coffee in general)
- ☐ Do you like **strong black coffee**?
(not all coffee, but 'strong black coffee' is still a general idea)

*Specific people or things (with **the**)*

- ☐ I like **the people I work with**.
(= a specific group of people)
- ☐ **The coffee we had after dinner** wasn't very good. (= specific coffee)

Exercises

75.1 Choose four of these things and write what you think about them:

bananas boxing cats crowds fast food horror movies
~~hot weather~~ maths opera snow supermarkets zoos

Use: I like ... / I don't like ... I think ... is/are ... I don't mind ...
 I love ... / I hate ... I'm (not) interested in ...

- 1 I don't like hot weather very much.
- 2
- 3
- 4
- 5

75.2 Which is right?

- 1 a Apples / ~~The apples~~ are good for you. (Apples is correct)
- b Look at apples / the apples on that tree. They're very big.
- 2 a Who are people / the people in this picture?
- b It annoys me when people / the people throw rubbish on the ground.
- 3 a My memory isn't good. I'm not good at remembering names / the names.
- b What were names / the names of those people we met last night?
- 4 a First World War / The First World War began in 1914 and ended in 1918.
- b A pacifist is somebody who is against war / the war.
- 5 a He's lazy. He doesn't like hard work / the hard work.
- b Did you finish work / the work you were doing yesterday?

75.3 Complete the sentences using the following. Use **the** where necessary.

~~(the) basketball~~ (the) grass (the) patience (the) people
 (the) questions (the) meat ~~(the) information~~ (the) hotels
 (the) biology (the) water (the) spiders (the) lies

- 1 My favourite sport is basketball.
- 2 The information we were given wasn't correct.
- 3 Some people are afraid of
- 4 A vegetarian is somebody who doesn't eat
- 5 The test wasn't hard. I answered without difficulty.
- 6 Do you know who live in the flat next to yours?
- 7 is the study of plants and animals.
- 8 It's better to tell the truth. Telling often causes problems.
- 9 We couldn't find anywhere to stay in the town. were all full.
- 10 Don't swim in this pool. doesn't look very clean.
- 11 Don't sit on It's wet after the rain.
- 12 You need to teach young children.

75.4 Which is right?

- 1 Steve is very good at telling stories / the stories.
- 2 I can't sing this song. I don't know words / the words.
- 3 Don't stay in that hotel. It's noisy and rooms / the rooms are very small.
- 4 I don't have a car, so I use public transport / the public transport most of the time.
- 5 All books / All the books on the top shelf belong to me.
- 6 Life / The life is strange sometimes. Some very strange things happen.
- 7 We enjoyed our holiday. Weather / The weather was good.
- 8 Everybody needs water / the water to live.
- 9 I don't like films / the films with unhappy endings.

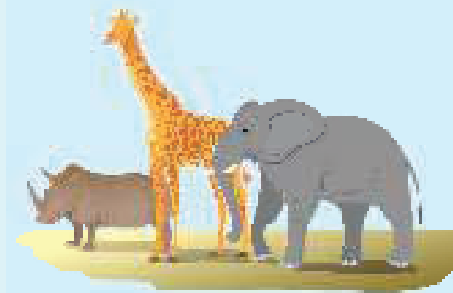
the 4 (the giraffe / the telephone / the old etc.)

A

Study these sentences:

- ☐ **The giraffe** is the tallest of all animals.
- ☐ **The bicycle** is an excellent means of transport.
- ☐ When was **the camera** invented?
- ☐ **The dollar** is the currency of the United States.

In these examples, **the** ... does not mean one specific thing.
The giraffe = a specific type of animal, not a specific giraffe.
 We use **the** ... in this way to talk about a type of animal, machine etc.



In the same way we use **the** for musical instruments:

- ☐ Can you play **the** guitar?
- ☐ **The** piano is my favourite instrument.

Compare **a** and **the**:

- ☐ I'd like to have **a piano**. *but* I can't play **the piano**.
- ☐ We saw **a giraffe** at the zoo. *but* **The giraffe** is my favourite animal.

Note that **man** (without **the**) = human beings in general, the human race:

- ☐ What do you know about the origins of **man**? (*not* the man)

B

the old, the rich etc.

We use **the** + *adjective* (without a noun) to talk about groups of people. For example:

the old	the rich	the homeless	the sick
the elderly	the poor	the unemployed	the injured

the old = old people, **the rich** = rich people etc. :

- ☐ Do you think **the rich** should pay higher taxes?
- ☐ We need to do more to help **the homeless**.

Note that we say: the **old** (*not* the olds), the **poor** (*not* the poors) etc.

The rich, the homeless etc. are *plural*. For one person, we say:

a rich man (*not* a rich) **a homeless person** (*not* a homeless)

C

the French, the Chinese etc.

We use **the** + a few nationality adjectives that end in **-ch** or **-sh**. For example:

the French the Dutch the British the English the Spanish

The meaning is *plural* – the people of that country.

- ☐ **The French** are famous for their food. (*not* French are ...)

We do not say 'a French' or 'an English' (*singular*). For example, we say:

- ☐ I met **a French woman** / **an English guy**.

We also use **the** + nationality words ending in **-ese** or **-ss**. For example:

the Chinese the Portuguese the Swiss

These words can also be singular (**a Chinese, a Swiss** etc.).

With other nationality words, the plural ends in **-s** (usually without **the**). For example:

an Italian → **Italians** a Mexican → **Mexicans** a Thai → **Thais**

- ☐ **Italians / Mexicans / Thais** are very friendly.

In all cases you can use *adjective* + **people**. For example, you can say:

- ☐ **French / Chinese / Mexican** people are very friendly.

Exercises

76.1 Answer the questions. Choose the right answer from the box. Don't forget **the**.

1

animals

tiger elephant
rabbit cheetah
giraffe kangaroo

2

birds

eagle penguin
swan owl
parrot pigeon

3

inventions

telephone wheel
telescope laser
helicopter typewriter

4

currencies

dollar peso
euro rupee
rouble yen

- 1 a Which of the animals is the tallest?
b Which animal can run the fastest?
c Which of these animals is found in Australia?
- 2 a Which of these birds has a long neck?
b Which of these birds cannot fly?
c Which bird flies at night?
- 3 a Which of these inventions is the oldest?
b Which one is the most recent?
c Which one was especially important for astronomy?
- 4 a What is the currency of India?
b What is the currency of Canada?
c And the currency of your country?

the giraffe

76.2 Put in **the** or **a**.

- 1 When was *the* telephone invented?
- 2 Can you play musical instrument?
- 3 Jessica plays violin in an orchestra.
- 4 There was piano in the corner of the room.
- 5 I wish I could play piano.
- 6 Our society is based on family.
- 7 Martin comes from large family.
- 8 computer has changed the way we live.
- 9 When was bicycle invented?
- 10 Do you have car?

76.3 Complete these sentences. Use **the** + adjective. Choose from:

elderly injured rich sick unemployed ~~young~~

- 1 *The young* have the future in their hands.
- 2 Helen is a nurse. She's spent her life caring for
- 3 Life is all right if you have a job, but things are hard for
- 4 Ambulances arrived at the scene of the accident and took to hospital.
- 5 More and more people are living longer. How are we going to care for?
- 6 It's nice to have lots of money, but have their problems too.

76.4 What do you call the people of these countries?

- | | <i>one person (a/an ...)</i> | <i>the people in general</i> |
|--------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| 1 Canada | <i>a Canadian</i> | <i>Canadians</i> |
| 2 Germany | | |
| 3 France | | |
| 4 Russia | | |
| 5 Japan | | |
| 6 Brazil | | |
| 7 England | | |
| 8 and your country | | |

Names with and without **the** 1

A

We do *not* use **the** with names of people ('Helen', 'Helen Taylor' etc.). In the same way, we do *not* use **the** with most names of places. For example:

continents
countries, states etc.
islands
cities, towns etc.
mountains

Africa (*not* the Africa), **South America**
France (*not* the France), **Japan, Texas**
Sicily, Tasmania
Cairo, Bangkok
Everest, Kilimanjaro



But we normally use **the** in names with **Republic, Kingdom, States** etc.:

the Czech Republic **the United Kingdom (the UK)**
the Dominican Republic **the United States of America (the USA)**

Compare:

- ☐ Have you been to **Canada** or **the United States**?

B

When we use **Mr/Ms/Captain/Doctor** etc. + a name, we do not use **the**. So we say:

Mr Johnson / **Doctor** Johnson / **Captain** Johnson / **President** Johnson etc. (*not* the ...)
Uncle Robert / **Saint** Catherine / **Queen** Catherine etc. (*not* the ...)

Compare:

- We called **the doctor**.
We called **Doctor** Johnson. (*not* the Doctor Johnson)

We use **Mount** (= mountain) and **Lake** before a name in the same way (without **the**):

Mount Everest (*not* the ...) **Mount** Etna **Lake** Superior **Lake** Victoria

- They live near **the lake**.
They live near **Lake Superior**. (*not* the Lake Superior)

C

We use **the** with the names of oceans, seas, rivers and canals:

the Atlantic (Ocean)	the Red Sea	the Amazon
the Indian Ocean	the Channel (between France and Britain)	the Nile
the Mediterranean (Sea)		the Suez Canal

We use **the** with the names of deserts:

the Sahara (Desert) the Gobi Desert

D

We use **the** with *plural* names of people and places:

people
countries
groups of islands
mountain ranges

the Taylors (= the Taylor family), **the Johnsons**
the Netherlands, **the Philippines**, **the United States**
the Canaries (or **the Canary Islands**), **the Bahamas**
the Andes, **the Alps**, **the Urals**

- ☐ The highest mountain in **the Andes** is (Mount) Aconcagua.

E

We say:

the north (of Brazil) *but* **northern** Brazil (*without the*)
the southeast (of Spain) *but* **southeastern** Spain

Compare:

- Sweden is in **northern Europe**; Spain is in **the south**.

We also use **north/south** etc. (*without the*) in the names of some regions and countries:

North America South Africa southeast Asia

Note that on maps, **the** is not usually included in the name.

Exercises

77.1 Which is right?

- 1 Who is Doctor Johnson / the Doctor Johnson? (Doctor Johnson is correct)
- 2 I was ill. Doctor / The doctor told me to rest for a few days.
- 3 Doctor Thomas / The Doctor Thomas is an expert on heart disease.
- 4 I'm looking for Professor Brown / the Professor Brown. Do you know where she is?
- 5 In the United States, President / the President is elected for four years.
- 6 President Kennedy / The President Kennedy was assassinated in 1963.
- 7 The officer I spoke to at the police station was Inspector Roberts / the Inspector Roberts.
- 8 Do you know Wilsons / the Wilsons? They're a very nice couple.
- 9 Julia spent three years as a student in United States / the United States.
- 10 France / The France has a population of about 66 million.

77.2 Some of these sentences are OK, but some need **the** (sometimes more than once). Correct the sentences where necessary.

- 1 Everest was first climbed in 1953.
- 2 Milan and Turin are cities in north of Italy.
- 3 Africa is much larger than Europe.
- 4 Last year I visited Mexico and United States.
- 5 Southern England is warmer than north.
- 6 Thailand and Cambodia are in southeast Asia.
- 7 Chicago is on Lake Michigan.
- 8 Next year we're going skiing in Swiss Alps.
- 9 UK consists of Great Britain and Northern Ireland.
- 10 Seychelles are a group of islands in Indian Ocean.
- 11 I've never been to South Africa.
- 12 River Volga flows into Caspian Sea.

OK

in the north of Italy

77.3 Here are some geography questions. Choose the right answer from one of the boxes and use **the** if necessary. You do not need all the names in the boxes.

continents	countries	oceans and seas	mountains	rivers and canals
Africa	Canada	Atlantic	Alps	Amazon Rhine
Asia	Denmark	Indian Ocean	Andes	Danube Thames
Australia	Indonesia	Pacific	Himalayas	Nile Volga
Europe	Sweden	Black Sea	Rockies	Suez Canal
North America	Thailand	Mediterranean	Urals	Panama Canal
South America	United States	Red Sea		

- 1 What do you have to cross to travel from Europe to America? the Atlantic
- 2 Where is Argentina?
- 3 Which is the longest river in Africa?
- 4 Of which country is Stockholm the capital?
- 5 Of which country is Washington the capital?
- 6 What is the name of the mountain range in the west of North America?
- 7 What is the name of the sea between Africa and Europe?
- 8 Which is the smallest continent in the world?
- 9 What is the name of the ocean between North America and Asia?
- 10 What is the name of the ocean between Africa and Australia?
- 11 Which river flows through London?
- 12 Which river flows through Vienna, Budapest and Belgrade?
- 13 Of which country is Bangkok the capital?
- 14 What joins the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans?
- 15 Which is the longest river in South America?

Names with and without **the** 2**A** Names without **the**

We do not use **the** with names of most city streets/roads/squares/parks etc.:

Union Street (*not the ...*) **Fifth Avenue** **Hyde Park**
Abbey Road **Broadway** **Times Square**

Names of many public buildings and institutions (airports, stations, universities etc.), and also some geographical names, are two words:

Manchester Airport **Harvard University**

The first word is the name of a place ('Manchester') or a person ('Harvard'). These names are usually without **the**. In the same way, we say:

Victoria Station (*not the ...*) **Canterbury Cathedral** **Edinburgh Castle**
Buckingham Palace **Cambridge University** **Sydney Harbour**

Compare:

Buckingham Palace (*not the ...*) *but* **the Royal Palace**
(‘Royal’ is an adjective – it is not a name like ‘Buckingham’.)

B Most other buildings have names with **the**. For example:

<i>hotels</i>	the Sheraton Hotel, the Holiday Inn
<i>theatres/cinemas</i>	the Palace Theatre, the Odeon (cinema)
<i>museums</i>	the Guggenheim Museum, the National Gallery
<i>other buildings</i>	the Empire State (Building), the White House, the Eiffel Tower

We often leave out the noun:

the Sheraton (Hotel) **the Palace** (Theatre) **the Guggenheim** (Museum)

Some names are only **the** + *noun*, for example:

the Acropolis **the Kremlin** **the Pentagon**

C Names with **of** usually have **the**. For example:

the Bank **of** England **the** Museum **of** Modern Art
the Great Wall **of** China **the** Tower **of** London

Note that we say:

the University **of** Cambridge *but* **Cambridge University** (*without the*)

D Many shops, restaurants, hotels etc. are named after people. These names end in **-s** or **-s**. We do not use **the** with these names:

McDonald's (*not the ...*) **Barclays** (bank)
Joe's Diner (restaurant) **Macy's** (department store)

Churches are often named after saints (St = Saint):

St John's Church (*not the ...*) **St Patrick's Cathedral**

E Most newspapers and many organisations have names with **the**:

the Washington Post **the** Financial Times **the** Sun (newspaper)
the European Union **the** BBC **the** Red Cross

Names of companies, airlines etc. are usually without **the**:

Fiat (*not the Fiat*) **Sony** **Singapore Airlines**
Kodak **IBM** **Yale University Press**

Exercises

- 78.1** Use the map to answer the questions. Write the name of the place and the street it is in. Use **the** if necessary. (Remember that on maps we do not normally use **the**.)



- 1 Is there a cinema near here?
- 2 Is there a supermarket near here?
- 3 Is there a hotel near here?
- 4 Is there a church near here?
- 5 Is there a museum near here?
- 6 Is there a bookshop near here?
- 7 Is there a restaurant near here?
- 8 Is there a park near here?

Yes, the Odeon in Market Street.

Yes, in

Yes, in

Yes, in

Yes, in

Yes, in

Yes, at the end of

- 78.2** Where are the following? Use **the** where necessary.

Acropolis
Kremlin

Broadway
White House

Buckingham Palace
Gatwick Airport

Eiffel Tower
Times Square

- 1 Times Square is in New York.
- 2 is in Paris.
- 3 is in London.
- 4 is in Washington.
- 5 is in Moscow.
- 6 is in New York.
- 7 is in Athens.
- 8 is near London.

- 78.3** Which is right?

- 1 Have you ever been to Science Museum / the Science Museum? (the Science Museum is correct)
- 2 Many tourists in London visit St Paul's Cathedral / the St Paul's Cathedral.
- 3 The biggest park in New York is Central Park / The Central Park.
- 4 I'd like to go to China and see Great Wall / the Great Wall.
- 5 Dublin Airport / The Dublin Airport is situated about 12 kilometres from the city centre.
- 6 'Which cinema are we going to this evening?' 'Classic / The Classic.'
- 7 Jack is a student at Liverpool University / the Liverpool University.
- 8 You should go to National Museum / the National Museum. It's very interesting.
- 9 If you're looking for a department store, I would recommend Harrison's / the Harrison's.
- 10 Andy is a flight attendant. He works for Cathay Pacific / the Cathay Pacific.
- 11 'Which newspaper do you want?' 'Morning News / The Morning News.'
- 12 We went to Italy and saw Leaning Tower / the Leaning Tower of Pisa.
- 13 This book is published by Cambridge University Press / the Cambridge University Press.
- 14 The building across the street is College of Art / the College of Art.
- 15 Imperial Hotel / The Imperial Hotel is in Baker Street / the Baker Street.
- 16 Statue of Liberty / The Statue of Liberty is at the entrance to New York Harbor / the New York Harbor.

Singular and plural

A

Sometimes we use a *plural* noun for one thing that has two parts. For example:

				
trousers (<i>two legs</i>) also jeans/tights/shorts/pants	pyjamas (<i>top and bottom</i>)	glasses	binoculars	scissors

These words are plural, so they take a plural verb:

- ☐ My **trousers are** too long. (*not* My trousers is)

You can also use **a pair of** + these words:

- ☐ **Those are** nice **jeans**. or That's **a** nice **pair of** jeans. (*not* a nice jeans)
☐ I need **some** new **glasses**. or I need **a** new **pair of** glasses.

B

Some nouns end in **-ics**, but are not usually plural. For example:

athletics gymnastics economics politics
physics electronics maths (= mathematics)

- ☐ **Gymnastics is** my favourite sport. (*not* Gymnastics are)

News is not plural (see Unit 70B):

- ☐ I have **some news** for you. **It's** good news!

Some words that end in **-s** can be singular or plural. For example:

means a means of transport **many means** of transport
series a TV series **two TV series**
species a species of fish **200 species** of fish

C

Some singular nouns are often used with a plural verb. For example:

audience committee company family firm government staff team

These nouns are all groups of people. We often think of them as a number of people (= they), not as one thing (= it). So we often use a plural verb:

- ☐ **The government** (= they) **have decided** to increase taxes.
☐ **The staff** at the company (= they) **are** not happy with **their** working conditions.

In the same way, we often use a plural verb after the name of a company or a sports team:

- ☐ **Shell have** increased the price of petrol.
☐ **Italy are** playing Brazil next Sunday (in a football match).

You can also use a singular verb (The government **wants** ... / Shell **has** ... etc.).

We use a plural verb with **police**:

- ☐ **The police are** investigating the crime, but **haven't** arrested anyone yet.
(not The police is ... hasn't)

Note that we say **a police officer** / **a policeman** / **a policewoman** (*not* a police).

D

We do not often use the plural of **person** ('persons'). We normally use **people** (a *plural* word):

- ☐ He's **a** nice **person**. *but* They are nice **people**. (*not* nice persons)
☐ **Many people don't** have enough to eat. (*not* Many people doesn't)

E

We think of a sum of money, a period of time, a distance etc. as *one* thing. So we use a singular verb:

- ☐ **Fifty thousand pounds** (= it) **was** stolen in the robbery. (*not* were stolen)
☐ **Three years** (= it) **is** a long time to be without a job. (*not* Three years are)
☐ **Two miles isn't** very far to walk.

Exercises

79.1 Complete the sentences. Choose from the box.

- 1 My eyesight is getting worse. I need glasses.
- 2 The trousers you bought for me fit me.
- 3 The jacket you bought for me fit me.
- 4 I need scissors to cut this piece of material.
- 5 I can't find my binoculars. Have you seen?
- 6 I went shopping and bought a of jeans.
- 7 Where my sunglasses?
- 8 I went shopping and bought pair of pyjamas.
- 9 I don't know much about politics. I'm not interested in

a
are
them
doesn't
pair
it
~~glasses~~
some
don't

79.2 Complete the sentences. Use a word from section B (news, series etc.).

- 1 'Have you heard the news?' 'No. What's happened?'
- 2 The bicycle is a of transport.
- 3 A lot of American TV are shown in other countries.
- 4 The tiger is an endangered
- 5 There will be a of meetings to discuss the problem.
- 6 Fortunately the wasn't as bad as we expected.
- 7 How many of bird are there in the world?
- 8 I didn't have my phone, so I had no of contacting you.

79.3 Choose the correct form of the verb, singular or plural. In three sentences either the singular or plural verb is possible.

- 1 Gymnastics is / ~~are~~ my favourite sport. (is is correct)
- 2 My new glasses doesn't / don't fit very well.
- 3 The police want / wants to interview two men about the robbery.
- 4 Physics was / were my favourite subject at school.
- 5 It's a nice place to visit. The people is / are very friendly.
- 6 Germany is / are playing Spain tomorrow night. Are you going to watch it?
- 7 Does / Do the police know how the accident happened?
- 8 Where do / does your family live?
- 9 Most people enjoy / enjoys music.
- 10 I like this cafe. The staff here is / are really friendly and efficient.

79.4 Complete the sentences. Use **is** or **isn't**, and choose from the box.

- 1 Three years is a long time to be without a job.
- 2 Thirty degrees for Tom. He doesn't like hot weather.
- 3 Ten dollars We need more than that.
- 4 Four days for a holiday. You need at least a week.
- 5 Twenty kilos Are you sure you can manage?

a lot to carry
enough money
too hot
long enough
a long time

79.5 Are these sentences OK? Correct them where necessary.

- 1 Three years are a long time to be without a job. Three years is a long time
- 2 The committee want to change the rules of the club. OK (wants is also correct)
- 3 Susan was wearing a black jeans.
- 4 I like Martin and Jane. They're very nice persons.
- 5 I'm going to buy some new pyjamas.
- 6 There was a police directing traffic in the street.
- 7 This scissors isn't very sharp.
- 8 The company have decided to open a new factory.
- 9 This plant is very rare species.
- 10 Twelve hours are a long time to be on a plane.

Noun + noun (a **bus driver** / a **headache**)

A You can use two nouns together (*noun + noun*) to mean *one* thing/person/idea etc. :
a **bus driver** **income tax** the **city centre** an **apple tree**

The first noun is like an adjective. It tells us what kind of thing/person/idea etc. :

a **bus driver** = the driver of a bus
income tax = tax that you pay on your income
 the **city centre** = the centre of the city
 an **apple tree** = a tree that has apples
 a **Paris hotel** = a hotel in Paris
 my **life story** = the story of my life

So you can say:

a **television** camera a **television** programme a **television** studio a **television** producer
 (things or people to do with television)
 language **problems** marriage **problems** health **problems** work **problems**
 (different kinds of problems)

Sometimes the first word ends in **-ing**:

a **frying** pan (= a pan for frying)
 a **washing** machine
 a **swimming** pool

B Sometimes there are more than two nouns together:

- ☐ I waited at the **hotel reception desk**.
- ☐ We watched the **World Swimming Championships** on TV.
- ☐ If you want to play table tennis (= a game), you need a **table tennis table** (= a table).

C When two nouns are together like this, sometimes we write them as one word and sometimes as two separate words. For example:

a **headache** **toothpaste** a **weekend** a **car park** a **road sign**

There are no clear rules for this. If you are not sure, write two words.

D Note the difference between:

a **coffee cup** (maybe empty) and a **cup of coffee** (= a cup with coffee in it)
 a **shopping bag** (maybe empty) and a **bag of shopping** (= a bag full of shopping)

E When we use *noun + noun*, the first noun is like an *adjective*. It is normally singular, but the meaning is often plural.

For example: a **car park** is a place to park **cars**, an **apple tree** is a tree that has **apples**.

In the same way we say:

a **three-hour** journey (= a journey that takes three **hours**)
 a **ten-pound** note (= a note with the value of ten **pounds**)
 a **four-week** course
 a **six-mile** walk
 two **14-year-old** girls

Compare:

☐ It was a **four-week** course. (*not* a four weeks course)
 but The course lasted four **weeks**.

Exercises

80.1 What do we call these things and people?

- 1 Someone who drives a bus is a bus driver
- 2 Problems concerning health are health problems
- 3 A ticket to travel by train is a
- 4 A machine you use to get a ticket is a
- 5 The staff at a hotel are the
- 6 The results of your exams are your
- 7 A horse that runs in races is a
- 8 A race for horses is a
- 9 Shoes for running are
- 10 A shop that sells shoes is a
- 11 The window of a shop is a
- 12 A person who cleans windows is a
- 13 A scandal involving a construction company is
- 14 Workers at a car factory are
- 15 A scheme for the improvement of a road is a
- 16 A department store in New York is a

80.2 Answer the questions using two of the following words each time:

accident	belt	birthday	card	credit	driver
forecast	machine	number	party	ring	road
room	seat	truck	washing	weather	wedding

- 1 This could be caused by bad driving. a road accident
- 2 You should wear this when you're driving. a
- 3 You can use this to pay for things. a
- 4 This will tell you if it's going to rain or not. the
- 5 This is useful if you have a lot of dirty clothes. a
- 6 This is something you might wear if you're married. a
- 7 If you're staying at a hotel, you need to remember this. your
- 8 This is a way to celebrate getting older. a
- 9 This person transports things by road. a

80.3 Put the words in the right order.

- 1 I spilt coffee on the living room carpet. (room / carpet / living)
- 2 Jack likes sport. He plays for his (team / school / football)
- 3 Anna works for a (company / production / film)
- 4 Many people invest in a (life / policy / insurance)
- 5 You can get a map at the (information / office / tourist)

80.4 Which is correct?

- 1 It's quite a big book. There are more than 500 page / 500 pages. (500 pages is correct)
- 2 It's only a two-hour / two hours flight from London to Madrid.
- 3 It took only two hour / two hours to fly to Madrid.
- 4 I don't have any change. I only have a twenty-pound / twenty pounds note.
- 5 I looked down and there were two ten-pound / ten pounds notes on the ground.
- 6 At work in the morning we usually have a 15-minute / 15 minutes break for coffee.
- 7 There are 60-minute / 60 minutes in an hour.
- 8 My office is on the tenth floor of a twelve-storey / twelve storeys building.
- 9 I work five-day / five days a week. Saturday and Sunday are free.
- 10 Five-star / Five stars hotels are the most expensive.
- 11 Sam's daughter is six-year-old / six years old.
- 12 Sam has a six-year-old / six-years-old daughter.

's (your sister's name) and of ... (the name of the book)

A

We use **-s** (*apostrophe + s*) mostly for people or animals:

- ☐ **Tom's** computer isn't working. (*not* the computer of Tom)
- ☐ How old are **Chris's** children? (*not* the children of Chris)
- ☐ What's (= What is) **your sister's** name?
- ☐ What's **Tom's sister's** name?
- ☐ Be careful. Don't step on **the cat's** tail.

You can use **-s** without a noun after it:

- ☐ This isn't my book. It's **my sister's**. (= my sister's book)

We do not use **-s** after a long group of words. So we say:

my friend's mother

but the mother **of the man we met yesterday** (*not* the man we met yesterday's mother)

Note that we say **a woman's hat** (= a hat for a woman), **a boy's name** (= a name for a boy), **a bird's egg** (= an egg laid by a bird) etc.

B

With a *singular* noun we use **-s**:

my **sister's** room (= **her** room – *one sister*)

Mr Carter's house (= **his** house)

With a *plural* noun (sisters, friends etc.) we put an apostrophe (') after **s**:

my sisters' room (= **their** room – *two or more sisters*)

the Carters' house (= **their** house – *Mr and Mrs Carter*)

If a plural noun does not end in **-s** (for example **men/women/children/people**) we use **-s**:

the **men's** changing room a **children's** book (= a book for children)

You can use **-s** after more than one noun:

Jack and Karen's children **Mr and Mrs Carter's** house

C

For things, ideas etc., we normally use **of**:

the temperature **of the water** (*not* the water's temperature)

the name **of the book** the owner **of the restaurant**

We say **the beginning/end/middle of ... / the top/bottom of ... / the front/back/side of ...**:

the beginning of the month (*not* the month's beginning)

the top of the hill **the back of** the car

D

You can usually use **-s** or **of ...** for an organisation (= a group of people). So you can say:

the government's decision *or* the decision **of the government**

the company's success *or* the success **of the company**

We also use **-s** for places. So you can say:

the city's streets **the world's** population **Italy's** prime minister

E

We use **-s** with time words (**yesterday / next week** etc.):

- ☐ Do you still have **yesterday's** newspaper?

- ☐ **Next week's** meeting has been cancelled.

In the same way, you can say **today's / tomorrow's / this evening's / Monday's** etc.

We also use **-s** (or **-s'** with plural words) with periods of time:

- ☐ I've got **a week's holiday** starting on Monday.
- ☐ Julia has got **three weeks' holiday**.
- ☐ I live near the station – it's only **ten minutes' walk**.

Exercises

81.1 In some of these sentences, it is more natural to use **-s** or **'s**. Change the underlined parts where necessary.

- 1 Who is the owner of this restaurant? OK
- 2 How old are the children of Chris? Chris's children
- 3 Is this the umbrella of your friend?
- 4 Write your name at the top of the page.
- 5 I've never met the daughter of James.
- 6 How old is the son of Helen and Andy?
- 7 We don't know the cause of the problem.
- 8 I don't know the words of this song.
- 9 The friends of your children are here.
- 10 What is the cost of a new washing machine?
- 11 The garden of our neighbours is very small.
- 12 The hair of David is very long.
- 13 I work on the ground floor of the building.
- 14 I couldn't go to the party of my best friend.
- 15 George is the brother of somebody I knew at college.
- 16 Have you seen the car of the parents of Ben?
- 17 What is the meaning of this expression?
- 18 Do you agree with the policy of the government?

81.2 Which is right?

- 1 Don't step on the cat's tail. (cat / cat's / cats')
- 2 It's my birthday tomorrow. (father / father's / fathers')
- 3 Those look nice. Shall we buy some? (apples / apple's / apples')
- 4 clothes are expensive. (Children / Children's / Childrens')
- 5 Zurich is largest city. (Switzerland / Switzerland's / Switzerlandds')
- 6 Your parents are your grandparents. (parents / parent's / parents')
- 7 I took a lot of when I was on holiday. (photos / photo's / photos')
- 8 This isn't my coat. It's (someone else / someone else's / someone elses')
- 9 Have you read any of poems? (Shakespeare / Shakespeare's / Shakespeares')

81.3 Read each sentence and write a new sentence beginning with the underlined words.

- 1 The meeting tomorrow has been cancelled.
Tomorrow's meeting has been cancelled.
- 2 The storm last week caused a lot of damage.
Last
- 3 The only cinema in the town has closed down.
The
- 4 The weather in Britain is very changeable.
.....
- 5 Tourism is the main industry in the region.
.....

81.4 Use the information given to complete the sentences.

- 1 If I leave my house at 9 o'clock and drive to the airport, I arrive at about 11.
So it's about two hours' drive from my house to the airport. (drive)
- 2 If I leave my house at 8.40 and walk to the centre, I get there at 9 o'clock.
So it's from my house to the centre. (walk)
- 3 I'm going on holiday on the 12th. I have to be back at work on the 26th.
So I've got (holiday)
- 4 I went to sleep at 3 o'clock this morning and woke up an hour later. After that I couldn't sleep.
So last night I only had (sleep)